Omar Assar from Egypt, World #26 Lily Zhang from the United States and World #17 Quadri Aruna from Nigeria are part of the 12-member international contingent. The exposure from UTT matches, players say, helps their development. "Beating foreign players at home boosts our confidence," notes Kamal. Adds Chitale, "To be a part of a team with experienced foreign players, to see how they train for matches and to get to learn from them and play against them is a good experience for me."

It's for these very reasons that reigning national champion Sreeja Akula is also looking forward to UTT. Additionally, Akula recognises how "local leagues help make the sport more visible", as has been the case with kabaddi and volleyball in India. Unlike other racquet sports like tennis and badminton, table tennis tournaments rarely get broadcast by sports channels, so UTT becomes the sole means to stay abreast with the sport. "It brings in more viewership and more spectators to come watch the sport," says Kamal. "The main target is to get the youngsters to try their hand at the sport. Once they do, it is addictive. All you need is a long table and you can play it in office or at home."

Playing on a dining table at home is how league promoter Vita Dani's love for table tennis began. The sport's easy accessibility, fun quotient and benefits such as improved hand-eye coordination are a few factors that made Dani, who also owns ISL football team Chennaiyin FC, back table tennis in India. In its fourth edition, Dani notes, there's interest from sponsors to add to the franchises, from international players to participate and from world federation presidents to attend. "It's a sweet position to be in," she says. Beyond that, her primary goal is to ensure the "pipeline of TT players continues". "I am sure we will create more heroes and I hope someday we can get an Olympic medal," she says. It's an ambition well worth nurturing. ■

Suhani Singh



WORLD ARCHERY

SPORTS

Aiming for the Stars

Archery champion Parth Salunkhe's career trajectory seems to be on track

Parth Salunkhe had heard a lot about Korean archers. On July 9 this year, at the World Archery Youth Championships in Ireland, he stood alongside one, Song Injun, in the recurve under-21 men's final. "Koreans are high-level athletes, who have earned a reputation through their performance. But I chose not to pay attention to who my opponent was and just maintained my process-oriented thinking," says Salunkhe.

The wet, cold conditions in Limerick were a contrast to the scorching heat of Sonipat, Haryana, where Salunkhe trains. The windy weather made it more difficult while taking aim. Salunkhe trailed at the start of the final, but an eight on the final arrow handed the 19-year-old the win and bragging rights as the first male youth world champion in recurve archery from India. Earlier in the week, he had teamed up with Ridhi to pick up bronze in the recurve under-21 mixed team event. India finished with 11 medals—six golds, a silver and four bronzes—the most at the event, though at second position behind Korea (six golds, four silvers).

Salunkhe, who is from Satara in Maharashtra, picked up archery at age seven. It wasn't love at first sight, though. He tried everything from cricket to kickboxing during the early days. But the tranquility of archery gradually drew him in.

At the first competition in Wai, he remembers scoring a 10. His progress was on track, but Salunkhe hit a roadblock when his coach quit. That's when his father, Sushant, donned the role of a guide and started learning the intricacies of archery through online videos. "Once he grasped things, he would explain it to me. My mother helped me with studies. Once archery took off, I didn't focus too much on studies," he says.

> Parth Salunkhe, who is **from Satara in Maharashtra**, picked up archery at the age of seven

After Salunkhe scored 82 per cent in his 10th grade, a big decision awaited the family the following year. "There's no guarantee of making a career in sports, but we took a call to pursue archery. It was quite stressful at the start, but once the medals started coming, we realised it would work out," says Salunkhe.

Moving away from home and to the Sports Authority of India centre in Sonipat was hard. But once Salunkhe immersed himself in the finer nuances of archery, he was hooked. Under coach Ram Avdesh, he's more confident and dreaming of an Olympic gold someday.

"I miss college life at times, but I also realise others haven't managed to achieve what I have at my age," he says. And that includes the title of a world champion. ■

Shail Desai